

Split Yellow Bus — Refined Cost Model

Based on Croatian Market Data and Public Procurement Records

Research basis: Croatian charter operator rate cards, public procurement tenders (SDŽ EVV 5/23, EVV 5/24, GPP Osijek 2025 bus purchase), Ministry of Education transport cost benchmarks, HAK fuel data, Croatian labour market salary data.

1. Market Rate Benchmarks (Croatia / Dalmatia Region)

1.1 Charter Bus Rates — 50-Seat Coach

Provider / Basis	Rate	Source
Bustravel.hr (Croatian operator)	1.20 EUR/km (51–61 seat coach)	Published rate card
Bustravel.hr daily flat	299 EUR/day (if < 250 km/day, 51–61 seat)	Published rate card
Bus Croatia (Dalmatia market)	800–1,100 EUR/day (full tourism day)	buscroatia.com
DirectBusTravel Split	800–1,000 EUR/day (8-hour coach)	directbustravel.com
Estimated contracted school-route rate	400–650 EUR/day (half-day, fixed route)	Market estimate (fixed predictable route = discounted vs. tourism)
Promet Split (public operator)	~1.00–1.30 EUR/km	promet-split.hr (rates not public; estimated)

Key insight: A fixed, predictable half-day school route (~3–4 hours, 80–100 km/day) commands a significant discount vs. a full tourism day. Contracted annual school routes in Croatia (e.g., SDŽ county tenders) are priced at the lower end.

1.2 State-Regulated Reference Rates

Rate	Amount	Source
Government mileage reimbursement (employee, private car)	0.15–0.16 EUR/km	MROSP 2025
MZO max co-financing for disability transport	0.80 EUR/km incl. VAT	NN 92/2024, MZOM decision 2025/26

Rate	Amount	Source
(contracted carrier)		
Parent/escort reimbursement rate	0.20–0.33 EUR/km	MZOM

The MZO benchmark of **0.80 EUR/km** represents the government’s reference price for contracted pupil transport. A competitive tender for the Yellow Bus would likely attract bids in the **1.00–1.50 EUR/km** range (full-service, operator-managed), with the difference funded by the city.

1.3 Driver Salaries — Croatia 2025

Metric	Net Monthly	Employer Annual Gross
National average (bus driver)	1,224 EUR	~19,000–21,000 EUR
National median	1,158 EUR	~18,000–20,000 EUR
Split market estimate (Promet Split range)	1,100–1,400 EUR net/month	~18,000–22,000 EUR/year
Zagreb (ZET, largest city)	~1,630 EUR total comp.	~24,000–26,000 EUR/year

Sources: adorio.hr, mojablaca.hr, HRT/ZET salary reporting

Split is a smaller labour market than Zagreb. Driver cost here is estimated at the lower end: **1,100–1,300 EUR net/month = 18,000–21,000 EUR gross employer cost/year.**

1.4 Vehicle Purchase Prices

Vehicle Type	Price Range	Notes
New school/interurban bus (50-seat, basic spec)	200,000–280,000 EUR	MAN Lion’s Intercity, Mercedes Intouro; Euro VI
New luxury tourist coach (50-seat)	350,000–450,000 EUR	Setra, MAN (not needed for school run)
Used coach (5–8 years old, Euro 6)	85,000–180,000 EUR	Market listings: TruckScout24, Mascus.hr
Used urban school bus (GPP Osijek 2025 benchmark)	114,000 EUR/vehicle	2016 vintage, 41-seat, 400–500k km — public procurement Sept 2025

Recommendation: Procure used 50-seat coaches (5–8 years, Euro 6) at **~100,000–140,000 EUR each**. This is the real-world Croatian public procurement price point, based on the GPP Osijek 2025 benchmark adjusted for 50-seat capacity.

1.5 Fuel Costs

Parameter	Value	Source
Current retail diesel price (Croatia, May 2026)	~1.32–1.40 EUR/litre	HAK, cijenegoriva.hr
Fuel consumption — interurban/school route	32–40 litres/100 km	HAK Revija; N1 Info (urban buses 38–48 L/100km; interurban lower)
Used for calculation:	35 L/100 km × 1.35 EUR/L	Conservative mid-estimate
Fuel cost per km	0.47 EUR/km	
Fuel cost per day (100 km round trip)	~47 EUR/day	
Fuel cost per year (180 school days)	~8,500 EUR/year per bus	

1.6 Maintenance and Insurance

Item	Annual Cost per Vehicle	Basis
Maintenance (tyres, service, parts)	6,000–9,000 EUR	~5–7% of purchase value/year (used vehicle)
Vehicle insurance (auto-odgovornost + kasko)	3,000–5,000 EUR	Dalmatia market estimate for 50-seat bus
MOT / periodic inspection (redovni pregled)	300–500 EUR	Croatian mandatory vehicle inspection
Total maintenance + insurance	9,300–14,500 EUR/year	

2. Full Cost Model — Three Scenarios

Scenario A: City Purchases Used Vehicles (Owner-Operator Model)

Capital costs (one-time):

Item	Cost
2 × used 50-seat bus (Euro 6, 2018–2020 vintage)	200,000–280,000 EUR
GPS tracking (2 vehicles)	3,000 EUR
Pick-up point signage and infrastructure	8,000–15,000 EUR
Total capital	211,000–298,000 EUR

Annual operating costs:

Item	Annual Cost
2 drivers (gross employer cost incl. social contributions)	36,000–44,000 EUR
Fuel (2 buses × 100 km/day × 180 days × 0.47 EUR/km)	16,920 EUR
Maintenance + insurance (2 vehicles)	18,600–29,000 EUR
Vehicle amortisation (10-year straight-line on 240,000 EUR)	24,000 EUR
Coordinator/admin	5,000 EUR
Total annual (including amortisation)	~100,500–119,000 EUR/year
Total annual (excluding amortisation — cash cost)	~76,500–95,000 EUR/year

5-year total cost (purchase + 5 years operating): - ~590,000–770,000 EUR (all-in, including vehicle residual value offset)

Scenario B: Contracted Charter Operator (Service Contract Model)

The City of Split (or SDŽ county on behalf of the city) issues a public tender for school transport services, following the existing EVV 5/23 / EVV 5/24 framework. Operator provides vehicle, driver, and maintenance.

Estimated contract price:

Basis	Annual Cost (2 buses)
Per-km model: 1.20 EUR/km × 100 km/day × 180 days × 2 routes	43,200 EUR
Daily rate model: 500 EUR/day × 180 days × 2 routes	180,000 EUR
Recommended: negotiated fixed annual contract	100,000–140,000 EUR/year

A fixed annual school-route contract is always cheaper than ad-hoc daily charter. The city should tender for a 3-year service contract with an option to extend to 5 years — longer contracts attract better pricing.

Capital costs (city): None. Operator bears vehicle cost.

5-year total cost: - ~500,000–700,000 EUR (contract model, no capital)

Scenario C: Pilot Only — Single Bus, Single Route, 6 Months (Recommended First Step)

Item	Cost
1 chartered bus, 6-month contract (180 days × 1 bus × 450 EUR/day)	81,000 EUR
Admin and coordination	3,000 EUR
Information materials for parents	2,000 EUR
Total pilot cost	~86,000 EUR

This is the lowest-risk entry point. A 6-month pilot with a single leased bus tests demand, proves operational feasibility, and provides real data for City Council before any capital commitment.

3. Cost Comparison: Yellow Bus vs. Alternatives

Option	Capital	Annual Operating	Time to Benefit	5-Year Total
Yellow Bus (owned fleet, 2 buses)	211,000–298,000 EUR	77,000–95,000 EUR	6–9 months	~590,000–770,000 EUR
Yellow Bus (contracted, 2 routes)	0 EUR	100,000–140,000 EUR	6–9 months	~500,000–700,000 EUR
Yellow Bus pilot (1 bus, 6 months)	0 EUR	86,000 EUR (one-time)	3–4 months	86,000 EUR
Build new school (Kila, eastern Split)	10,000,000–15,000,000 EUR	800,000+ EUR/year	5–8 years	N/A
NPOO expansion at Ravne Njive	18,200,000 EUR (3 schools total)	—	3–5 years	N/A
Temporary prefab classrooms	300,000–600,000 EUR	50,000 EUR/year	1–2 years	~550,000 EUR

The Yellow Bus pilot (86,000 EUR) is the cheapest option that provides real relief to real children within the current academic year.

4. Procurement Framework — How to Buy This Legally

The SDŽ County Model (Existing Precedent)

Splitsko-dalmatinska County already procures school transport services via: - **EVV 5/23** — “Prijevoz učenika osnovnih škola na području SDŽ (2 grupe)” — EOJN tender 39799 - **EVV 5/24** — Repeat tender for 2024/25 school year

These are open public procurement procedures under the **Zakon o javnoj nabavi (ZJN)**.
The City of Split could:

Option 1: Request SDŽ County to include Split intra-city routes in the existing annual tender framework — lowest administrative burden.

Option 2: Conduct its own below-threshold procurement (ispod EU praga) — estimated annual contract value likely below the EU works threshold, enabling simplified procedure.

Option 3: Direct award to Promet Split (city-owned public transport company) as an in-house/Teckal exemption, avoiding full open tender — legally viable since Promet Split is owned by the City.

Recommendation for pilot: Direct award to Promet Split for a 6-month pilot contract. Fast, legal (Teckal doctrine), avoids 6-month procurement timeline, and leverages existing operational capacity.

5. Funding Sources

Source	Applicability	Notes
City of Split education budget	Primary	Direct line item; City already funds student transport (free passes)
Ministarstvo znanosti i obrazovanja (MZO)	Co-financing possible	MZO co-finance transport for specific pupil categories; pilot may qualify
Splitsko-dalmatinska County	County may contribute	SDŽ already funds inter-settlement school transport
EU funds (ESF+, ERDF)	Secondary	Educational equity programmes may fund transport innovation; requires project formulation
NPOO (existing allocation)	Unlikely direct	NPOO allocation is building-specific; not straightforwardly repurposable

Most realistic initial model: City of Split funds the pilot entirely (~86,000 EUR) from the education budget. If the pilot succeeds, seek MZO co-financing for scale.

6. Key Numbers for Presentation

€86,000 — Cost of a 6-month pilot with one bus **€100,000–140,000/year** — Annual contracted cost of the full 2-bus service **€114,000/vehicle** — What GPP Osijek paid for a used school bus in September 2025 (public procurement benchmark) **1.20 EUR/km** — Published charter rate for a 50-seat coach in Croatia (Bustravel.hr) **1,200 EUR/month net** — Average Croatian bus driver salary **€0.47/km** — Fuel cost (35 L/100 km at current diesel prices) **180 school days/year** — Operating days **100 km/day** — Estimated daily round trip per bus (eastern Split ↔ centre) **€10–15 million** — Cost of one new school building in eastern Split